

‘How’d he do it?’ I asked, in awe of the possibility of graduating debt-free and how so much money could be made in the market.

‘His dad works in finance,’ my friend replied.

‘Well my family doesn’t work in finance, so I guess I’ll never know how to invest’ somehow seemed like the most logical thing to say at the time.

Let’s unpack that for a moment: I didn’t bother to open my mind to the possibility of asking more questions. If I didn’t understand something, why didn’t I ask? There are so many questions now that I would have asked:

*Who was he?*

*How did he do it?*

*Could I talk to him?*

*Was this something I could learn?*

*Was there a book or resource his dad could recommend?*

Instead, young Simran shut down the idea of investing before she even gave herself a chance to explore the concept further. She didn’t believe she was capable of learning, so she didn’t bother trying. That was my second run-in with investing, yet, despite being older than nine, my response was still the same:

*It must be me. I’m just not smart enough to understand how to invest.*

The world of investing has never really opened its arms to women or minorities. At best it’s maybe looked over its shoulder at us and given a shrug. Or perhaps reluctantly invited us to the party hoping the invite would somehow get lost in the mail. Financial education has been scarce, and it has not been accessible. The jargon is full of heteronormative, classist and guilt-inducing language. No wonder no-one is listening.

It’s a concept women and minorities around the world are all too familiar with. With a number of studies showing only 16 to 20 per cent of women invest, and with women only having 44 cents for every dollar of men’s wealth (according to the US 2019 Survey of Consumer Finances, conducted by the Federal Reserve Board), we’re lagging behind when it comes to financial wellness and growth.